Diaspora. The report used the word to refer to NRI citizens and People of Indian Origin (PIO) who did not hold Indian citizenship but were linked to the country up to four generations, or by marriage, with caveats on the countries of destination. It is this definition, of relatively recent emigrants and their descendants, which I use in this chapter.

There is one Indian diaspora that is popular in the public imagination, but it is also the amalgamation of sub-national Indian diasporas defined principally by language. One can therefore talk about a Tamil diaspora, a Bengali diaspora or a Telugu diaspora. Most crucially, these diasporas reside *within* and *outside* India. In fact, when viewed from this prism, the internal diasporas of India are double the size of the international diaspora and are closely linked with each other. As we will see, the evolution of India's internal and international diasporas have popularized the very idea of Indian diversity.

Tiding over the *Kaalapani*

To understand the evolution of the international Indian diaspora, it is useful to begin with a brief statistical overview. Before the 19th century, few people born in the Indian subcontinent were found in the Americas, Europe or West Africa. India and Indians had captivated the imaginations of the others, but the reverse was not necessarily true. As described in the previous chapter, traditional destinations of merchants outside the Indian subcontinent included central Asia, South East Asia and East Africa. The numbers involved were small, perhaps less than 50,000 in total.[3] The fear of the kaalapani (black waters) constrained migration choices for the vast majority.

With the advent of organized indentured labour migration to Mauritius in 1834 as part of the colonial economic system, the number of emigrants began to increase. Migration to British Guiana, now the independent nation of Guyana, began in 1838 and to Trinidad and Jamaica in 1845. By 1850, the international Indian diaspora had crossed the 1,00,000-mark. The majority lived in Mauritius with its roots in the Chhota Nagpur Plateau and